don’t forget to collect the walnuts under the tree.” He smiled. “There should be plenty on the ground by now. Virginie can use the rail carts to store them, making it easier for everyone.”

“That’s enough.” The soldier stepped forward, pulling Édouard away.

She wanted to tell him one more thing, hoping to ease his mind. “I cleaned out three barrels.”

“Thank you, Léa, for everything.” His eyes were full of sadness. “And tell my wife and daughter how much I love them.”

Léa listened as his footsteps echoed across the parquet floor, trying to push away the thought that it might be the last time she’d see him.

* * *

“Rail carts?” Virginie frowned. “That was his message?”

Léa had told Rose and Virginie everything Édouard said, hoping there might be some hidden message that only Virginie would grasp.

“Are you sure he said rail carts?” She shook her head. “I have no idea.”

“He said they could be used to collect the walnuts.”

“Could my poor husband have lost his mind? We collected the walnuts last week.” She held out her palms, the fingers tinged with dark brown streaks. “It takes weeks for the dye from the inner casing to fade. We peeled them all off, then arranged them on the greenhouse floor to dry.”

“It must mean something,” Rose said. “Why else would he mention it?”

“How did he look?” A crease of worry appeared on Virginie’s forehead.

“Good,” Léa lied.

A loud knock startled the women as they turned to the door.

“Who could that be?” Virginie advanced to the front of the farmhouse. Rose and Léa followed close behind.

“Madame LeBlanc?” A short man with a swarthy face stood at the threshold. He removed his hat and tilted his head down in a bow. “Paul Ferney. I’ve been sent by Weinführer Brucker.”

“Oh . . .” Virginie hesitated, and turned to Léa.

“I’ll show you around the *chai*,” Léa said, stepping through the threshold to introduce herself. “That’s where we need assistance.” Léa strode across the courtyard.

“Are you also a winegrower, Monsieur Ferney?”